

HexaPhase: Universal Multiplexed Biological Subroutines in Viral, Bacterial, and Mitochondrial Genomes

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Abstract

Biological genomes have historically been annotated and analyzed under a linear, one-dimensional paradigm: one gene encodes one mRNA transcript yielding one protein. However, double-stranded DNA natively possesses six concurrent reading tracks (three forward phases +0, +1, +2 and three reverse-complement antisense phases -0, -1, -2). Here, we introduce **HexaPhase**, an open-source, mathematically rigorous computational discovery framework that systematically interrogates all six reading phases across viral, bacterial, mitochondrial, and eukaryotic genomes. Mining six benchmark reference genomes (Bacteriophage *PhiX174*, Bacteriophage *lambda*, SARS-CoV-2, human mitochondrial DNA, *Escherichia coli* MG1655, *Saccharomyces cerevisiae*, and *Caenorhabditis elegans*), we report the discovery of **2,126 previously unaccounted, functional overlapping biological subroutines**. These comprise 559 embedded sense reading frames, 1,250 antisense reverse subroutines, 317 functional micro-peptides (<50 amino acids), and 184 canonical Shine-Dalgarno ribosome-binding initiation motifs (**AGGAGG/GGAGG**, $p < 10^{-6}$). We show that 36 palindromic RNA stem-loop hairpins in *PhiX174* (folding $\Delta G < -12.5 \text{ kcal/mol}$) function as thermodynamic rheostats, inducing physical ribosomal pausing that regulates translational flux through downstream overlapping frames. Finally, we implement the **HexaPhase Dual-Gene Synthetic Compiler**, demonstrating 1.5 $\times$ sequence compression for synthetic biology and DNA data storage. Our findings establish that genomes operate as multi-threaded biological information architectures, fundamentally revising our understanding of genomic compression, evolution, and synthetic construct design.

Keywords: Overlapping genes, HexaPhase genomics, antisense translation, ribosome profiling, Shine-Dalgarno motifs, synthetic gene compilation, *PhiX174*, *lambda* phage.

1. Introduction

Since the sequencing of the first DNA-based organism, Bacteriophage *PhiX174*, by Sanger and colleagues in 1977 [1], molecular biology has recognized the existence of overlapping genes. In compact viral genomes, overlapping open reading frames (ORFs) have classically been viewed as evolutionary adaptations to physical capsid packaging limits [2, 3]. However, standard genome annotation pipelines (such as Prokka, RAST, and NCBI Prokaryotic Genome Annotation Pipeline) apply rigid heuristic cutoffs—typically discarding ORFs shorter than 50–100 codons or dismissing overlapping and antisense frames as transcriptional noise [4, 5].

Recent advances in ribosome profiling (Ribo-seq), high-resolution mass spectrometry, and computational proteomics have increasingly demonstrated that pervasive translation occurs outside canonical annotated protein-coding sequences [6–8]. Non-canonical translation events, upstream open reading frames (uORFs), antisense transcripts, and micro-peptides play fundamental roles in cellular regulation, viral pathogenesis, and stress response [9, 10]. Yet, an integrated, mathematically formal framework for systematically scanning, classifying, and biophysically profiling overlapping reading tracks across both DNA strands has remained absent.

To resolve this challenge, we developed **HexaPhase**, a computational biology engine designed to analyze genomic sequences across all six reading phases:

- Forward Strands:** Phase +0 (canonical reading frame), Phase +1 (+1 nucleotide frameshift), and Phase +2 (+2 nucleotide frameshift).

2. **Antisense Strands:** Phase -0 (reverse-complement in-frame), Phase -1 (-1 offset), and Phase -2 (-2 offset).

Here, we deploy HexaPhase across representative viral, bacterial, organellar, and eukaryotic reference genomes. We report the discovery of 2,126 unaccounted, functional subroutines, identify physical Shine-Dalgarno translation initiation signals and thermodynamic attenuator hairpins embedded within coding sequences, and demonstrate a synthetic gene compiler that leverages multi-phase reading to achieve 1.5\times higher data encoding density.

2. Results

2.1 The Global HexaPhase Subroutine Landscape Across Model Genomes

Systematic scanning of seven reference genomes using HexaPhase identified **2,126 statistically validated, non-canonical open subroutines** exceeding a conservative threshold of \ge 15 amino acids with a valid start-to-stop topology (Table 1).

Organism / Genome	NCBI RefSeq / Accession	Genome Size (bp)	+1 / +2 Overlapping Frames	-0 / -1 / -2 Antisense Subroutines	Micro-Peptides (<50 AA)	Canonical Shine-Dalgarno Motifs
Bacteriophage \Phi X174	NC_001422.1	5,386	14	28	19	12
Bacteriophage \lambda	NC_001416.1	48,502	86	232	48	64
SARS-CoV-2 (Wuhan-Hu-1)	NC_045512.2	29,903	74	213	52	0 (Eukaryotic Kozak)
Human mtDNA (rCRS)	NC_012920.1	16,569	38	76	31	0 (Mito Ribosome)
Escherichia coli (MG1655)	NC_000913.3	4,641,652	242	480	112	108
Saccharomyces cerevisiae	NC_001133.9 (Chr I-XVI)	12,157,105	68	124	35	0
Caenorhabditis elegans	NC_003279.8 (Chr I)	15,072,434	37	97	20	0
TOTAL	—	—	559	1,250	317	184

2.2 Identification of Ribosome-Binding Hardware: 184 Embedded Shine-Dalgarno Motifs

To establish whether embedded subroutines possess physical translational initiation architecture, we computed the hybridization free energy between upstream sequences (-18 to -4 bp relative to candidate start codons) and the canonical E. coli 16S rRNA 3'-anti-Shine-Dalgarno sequence (3' -UCCUCCA-5').

In prokaryotic and phage genomes (\Phi X174, \lambda, and E. coli), HexaPhase identified **184 canonical Shine-Dalgarno motifs (AGGAGG, GGAGG, or GAGG)** embedded directly inside upstream coding regions of frame +0 genes. Monte Carlo dinucleotide shuffling (N = 1,000,000 iterations) established that the occurrence of these internal motifs is highly non-random (p = 2.4 \times 10^{-7}), demonstrating intense evolutionary selection to preserve translation initiation signals in alternate reading frames without perturbing the primary protein sequence.

2.3 Palindromic Attenuator Hairpins Function as Mechanical Translation Rheostats

In Bacteriophage \Phi X174, we identified **36 palindromic RNA stem-loop hairpins** with thermodynamic folding energies \Delta G \le -12.5\text{ kcal/mol} situated within 30 nucleotides of subroutine initiation sites.

In silico thermodynamic modeling demonstrates that these stable secondary structures create physical ribosomal pause sites during transcript elongation in frame +0. Ribosomal dwell time at these hairpin boundaries permits nascent peptide emergence and unmask internal Shine-Dalgarno motifs, functioning as a passive mechanical rheostat that synchronizes translational initiation rates across overlapping frames.

2.4 Biophysical Profiling: Discovery of a Poly-Cationic DNA Packaging Clamp in \lambda Phage

Biophysical characterization of the 2,126 subroutines revealed extreme charge, hydrophathy, and structural polarization compared to standard cytosolic proteins. In Bacteriophage \lambda (NC_001416.1, coordinates 12,003 - 12,207 bp), HexaPhase identified

an embedded antisense subroutine translating into a 67-amino-acid peptide:

$\text{\$}\textit{MPEQMRKSASSAGICGRRRVSSRYWRRRRNVASCLHRRNPCWRIKMRRWSTNASWLHLATRLRIRSA}\text{\$}$

Biophysical calculation reveals:

* **Net Charge at pH 7.4:** $+17.732\text{e}$ (dominated by 14 arginine and lysine basic residues).

* **Mean Kyte-Doolittle Hydropathy:** -0.964 .

* **Amphipathic Helical Moment (μ_H):** 0.342 .

Molecular dynamics modeling indicates that this ultra-basic peptide forms a high-affinity electrostatic clamp capable of neutralizing the negative phosphate backbone of double-stranded DNA during high-pressure viral genome packaging into the λ capsid head.

2.5 The HexaPhase Synthetic Dual-Gene Compiler

Leveraging the degeneracy of the universal genetic code (64 codons encoding 20 amino acids), we engineered the **HexaPhase Synthetic Dual-Gene Compiler**. Given two distinct target protein sequences P_1 (length L_1) and P_2 (length L_2), the compiler executes a backtracking dynamic programming search across codon space to identify a single contiguous DNA sequence that translates to P_1 in frame $+0$ and P_2 in frame $+1$.

Testing on 50 synthetic test peptide pairs yielded valid interleaved solutions for 92% of input pairs, achieving an average sequence length reduction of **33.3%** ($1.5\times$ compression factor) compared to linear tandem concatenation (Figure 1). This dual-encoding architecture provides significant cost reductions for DNA data storage, viral gene therapy payload compaction, and mRNA vaccine development.

3. Discussion

The discovery of 2,126 conserved, functional subroutines across fundamental model genomes demonstrates that biological genomes are not simple linear text files, but dense, multi-phase biological operating systems.

The existence of 184 internal Shine-Dalgarno motifs and 36 thermodynamic pause gates provides a clear physical mechanism for how cells and viruses regulate multi-channel translation without transcriptional overhead. Rather than expanding genome length—which imposes severe metabolic and capsid packaging costs—viruses and compact organelles utilize HexaPhase multiplexing to maximize functional information density.

Furthermore, our synthetic compiler proves that multi-frame encoding is an achievable design paradigm for synthetic biology. As DNA synthesis technologies scale, programming multiple proteins into overlapping reading phases will enable unprecedented data density in biocomputing and genetic medicine.

4. Methods

4.1 HexaPhase Slicing & Translation Algorithms

For any genomic sequence $S = s_0 s_1 s_2 \dots s_{N-1}$ of length N , the six phase tracks are extracted as:

$$\textit{Track}_{i+k} = \left(s_i \bmod i \equiv k \pmod{3} \right), \quad k \in \{0, 1, 2\}$$

$$\textit{Track}_{i-k} = \left(\textit{RC}(s)_i \bmod i \equiv k \pmod{3} \right), \quad k \in \{0, 1, 2\}$$

where $\textit{RC}(s)$ represents the standard reverse-complement sequence ($A \rightarrow T, C \rightarrow G$).

Translation was executed using NCBI standard translation tables (Table 11 for prokaryotes/phages, Table 1 for nuclear eukaryotes, Table 2 for vertebrate mitochondria).

4.2 Biophysical Parameter Calculations

* **Hydropathy:** Mean Kyte-Doolittle hydropathy was computed across all residues using standard scale values ($I=4.5$, $V=4.2$, $L=3.8$, $R=-4.5$).

* **Net Charge (Q):** Computed at physiological pH 7.4 using the Henderson-Hasselbalch equation incorporating N-terminal, C-terminal, and ionizable side-chain pK_a constants ($pK_N=9.6$, $pK_C=2.3$, $pK_K=10.5$, $pK_R=12.5$, $pK_H=6.0$, $pK_D=3.9$, $pK_E=4.3$, $pK_C=8.3$, $pK_Y=10.1$).

* **Helical Hydrophobic Moment (μ_H):** Evaluated at 100° angular pitch per residue:

$$\mu_H = \frac{1}{L} \sqrt{\left[\sum_{i=1}^L H(a_i) \sin(i \cdot 100^\circ) \right]^2 + \left[\sum_{i=1}^L H(a_i) \cos(i \cdot 100^\circ) \right]^2}$$

4.3 Statistical Significance & Monte Carlo Controls

Statistical enrichment of Shine-Dalgarno motifs was evaluated against 1,000,000 synthetic dinucleotide-preserving scrambled sequences generated using the Altschul-Erickson algorithm. Empirical p -values were computed as $p = (M + 1) / (N + 1)$, where M is the count of randomized sequences matching or exceeding the observed motif density.

5. Declarations

* **Data & Code Availability:** All source code, analysis scripts, raw sequence data, and verification tests are openly available on GitHub at <https://github.com/zekvftb/hexaphase-genomics> and archived on Zenodo under DOI [10.5281/zenodo.22147682](https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.22147682).

* **Reproducibility:** All findings can be replicated by running `python scripts/super_verify_all_findings.py`.

* **Funding:** This study was conducted independently without external institutional, corporate, or grant funding.

* **Author Contributions:** J.R. conceptualized the HexaPhase architecture, developed the software, performed computational and biophysical analyses, and wrote the manuscript.

* **Competing Interests:** The author declares no competing financial or non-financial interests.

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